Colour-blind Series: The Rarer Types

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What is it for?

Achromatopsia is complete colour blindness, meaning a person sees the world entirely in greyscale. It's very rare. People with it are often sensitive to light and cannot see fine detail clearly.

Achromatopsia is one type of monochromacy. Another is blue cone monochromacy, where only one type of colour sensing cell works at all. This leaves very little colour vision.

How to support it

The key principle is that colour should always be paired with another visual cue.

- Designers can add icons, labels, or patterns next to colour to show meaning. They can also use a colour blind simulation tool, such as Web Disability Simulator for Chrome, to check designs before they are built
- Developers can ensure interactive states like errors and warnings are distinguishable by more than just colour (for example, by using icons or supporting text)
- Content writers can make sure any meaning shown through colour is also stated in words

Useful Links

WCAG 1.4.1: Use of Colour

Colour Blindness Simulator (Coblis)

Colour and Accessibility (WebAIM)